Office of Research Assurance

Human Subject Research Protections Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP-103: Cooperative Research – Individual Investigator Acknowledgement (IIA)

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Version
103	9/17/2025	v.4.2	v.4.1

Purpose

ORA:SOP-103 establishes the NASA IRB process and responsibilities for human subjects research involving a collaborating investigator who is not affiliated with an institution or organization holding a US Department of Health & Human Services (HHS) Office of Human Research Protections (OHRP)[1] Federalwide Assurance (FWA). In some situations, the NASA IRB may agree to extend their FWA to cover the individual.

The individual researcher's agreement to abide by applicable laws, policies, and standards for the protections of human subjects as well as all determinations and requirements of the NASA IRB are documented in an **Individual Investigator Acknowledgement (IIA)**. This policy describes the NASA IRB's policies and procedures for assuming oversight responsibilities and compliance under an IIA.

Related documents **ORA:SOP-101** and **ORA:SOP-102** outline the processes and responsibilities for shared oversight between the NASA IRB and an external institution holding an active FWA. **ORA:SOP-104** establishes the process for collaborators located at an institution outside of the United States without an active FWA.

In general, the NASA IRB does not require an **Individual Investigator Acknowledgement (IIA**) for research projects determined to be exempt according 14 CFR 1230.104(d), unless limited IRB review is required or in limited cases as determined appropriate by NASA.

Policy

1. The NASA IRB review of proposed research will meet human subject protection requirements [14 CFR 1230, NPR 7100.1, NPD 7100.8, NPR 1382.1, NPD 1382.17, and FDA 21 CFR 50, 56, 312, and 812], as applicable.
2. The NASA IRB will follow written procedures for reporting its findings and actions to the appropriate officials at the Collaborating Investigator's Institution/Site as noted in this policy's 'Responsibilities,' whenever applicable.

[1] Note: If HHS-conducted or -supported human subjects research activities routinely occur at a non-assured institution, the institution should obtain an OHRP-approved FWA. Also, if the non-assured institution is the primary awardee for an HHS-supported award providing support for non-exempt human subjects research, the institution must obtain its own OHRP-approved FWA. If an institution is uncertain about the need for its own FWA, it should consult with OHRP [(Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP), 2005)].

Responsibilities

The **NASA IRB Office within the Office of Research Assurance (ORA)** is responsible for facilitating the efficient and accurate execution of the procedures listed in this policy.

NASA IRB

When the NASA IRB agrees to enter an Individual Investigator Agreement (IIA), NASA is agreeing to bring the individual researcher under the oversight responsibility of the NASA held Federalwide Assurance (FWA).

Responsibilities of ***NASA IRB*** in an IIA include, but are not limited to:

1. Maintain an active Federalwide Assurance (FWA) with OHRP.
2. Review the research according to all applicable regulations, laws, and relevant NASA policies.
3. Maintain documentation of the IIA and provide to OHRP upon request.

Collaborating Individual Investigator

Responsibilities of **Collaborating Individual Investigators** include:

1. Protecting the rights and welfare of human subjects involved in research conducted under the IIA and comply with the standards and requirements stipulated in:
    a. *The Belmont Report: Ethical Principles and Guidelines for the Protection of Human Subjects of Research*),
    b. applicable regulations for the protection of Human Subjects: NASA at 14 CFR 1230; and the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) at 21 CFR 50, 56, 312, and 812, when appropriate,
    c. applicable terms of the NASA IRB FWA, and
    d. relevant NASA policies and procedures for the protection of human subjects (NPD 7100.1, NPD 7100.8, NPR 1382.1, NPD 1382.17,).
2. Ensuring compliance with their own institutional/organizational/entity policies, applicable laws, regulations, and other local considerations.
3. Communicating any relevant local information to the NASA IRB and overall Principal Investigator (e.g., local laws that are relevant to the proposed research activities).
4. Abiding by determinations of the NASA IRB and accepting the final authority and decisions of the NASA IRB.
5. Seeking prior approval through the IRB for any changes in the research, except where necessary to eliminate apparent immediate hazards to subjects.
6. Immediately reporting to the Overall PI and the NASA IRB any unanticipated problems involving risks to subjects or others in research.
7. When responsible for enrolling subjects, the collaborating Investigator will obtain, document, and maintain records of informed consent.
8. Submitting the NASA Conflict of Interest (COI) disclosures and documentation of any related management plans to the NASA IRB through the eIRB platform.

9. Providing additional documentation as determined necessary by the NASA IRB for the purpose of study review, approval, continuing review, recordkeeping, reporting, or certification.

NASA Principal Investigator

When an Individual Investigator Acknowledgement (IIA) is executed for individuals on a project, the ***NASA Principal Investigator*** is responsible for appropriately supervising all collaborative research activities to be performed by the collaborating individual investigator.

Procedures

1. The Overall NASA PI is encouraged to reach out to the NASA IRB staff in advance to determine whether establishment of an Individual Investigator Acknowledgement (IIA) is necessary and appropriate.
    a. When appropriate, providing the IRB staff with a Point of Contact (POC) at the external organization can facilitate the process.
2. The Collaborating Individual Investigator completes and returns the IIA to NASA IRB staff.
3. Upon receipt of the partially executed IIA form, NASA IRB staff:
    a. Send the partially executed IIA form to the Office of the Chief Health and Medical Officer (OCHMO) designee for signature.
    b. NASA IRB staff forward the fully executed IIA form to the Overall PI and the Collaborating Individual Investigator.
4. The NASA PI adds the collaborating individual as personnel to a new or existing study following nominal processes in the eIRB and attaches on the STUDY TEAM page:
    a. Fully executed Individual Investigator Acknowledgement (IIA)
    b. COI disclosure and management plan, if applicable
    c. Documentation of current training in Human Subjects Research Protections
5. The NASA IRB Office finalizes review of the study following normal procedures, ensuring that the executed IIA is included in the eIRB attachments.
6. Terminating the Acknowledgement(s)
    a. The IIA is in effect once fully executed by both the NASA IRB and the Collaborating Individual Investigator and continues until the study is closed or the individual is removed from the study personnel listing.
    b. The NASA IRB may terminate an IIA through written notification of termination to the Overall PI and Individual Investigator including the effective end date and reason for termination.

Definitions

Cooperative Research: those projects covered by this policy that involve more than one institution. Research may be designated within the eIRB as “Multi-site or Collaborative” studies.

Engaged:[2] NASA is considered engaged in human subjects research requiring NASA IRB review when:

1. NASA's employees or agents obtain:
    a. data about the participants of the research through intervention or interaction with them,
    b. identifiable private information or identifiable biospecimens about the participants of research, or
    c. the informed consent of human subjects for the research.
2. Human subjects research per 14 CFR 1230/21 CFR 56:
    a. is conducted under a contract or Space Act Agreement identifying NASA IRB as the IRB of Record
    b. is conducted on NASA property,
    c. includes NASA employees or agents as study participants,
    d. uses NASA employees' or agents' identifiable private information or identifiable biospecimens, or
    e. uses identifiable private information or identifiable biospecimens from NASA repositories

Federalwide Assurance (FWA): Written assurance of compliance submitted by an institution which commits that it will comply with requirements set forth in the regulations for the protection of human subjects at 45 CFR 46 and 14 CFR 1230 as well as the Terms of Assurance. NASA utilizes the FWA and does not require a NASA-specific assurance process.

Individual Investigator Agreement (IIA): Mechanism under which an institution holding an Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP)-approved Federalwide Assurance (FWA) may extend the applicability of its FWA to cover collaborating investigators from an institution without an active FWA.

Institution [14 CFR 1230.102]: any public or private entity or agency (including federal, state, and other agencies).

Reviewing IRB (IRB of Record): The IRB responsible for conducting review and oversight of a collaborative research project, to which oversight activities have been ceded by the Relying IRB or Relying Site(s).

Study Personnel: In addition to PI, those involved in the conduct of human subject research in which the persons engaged are in direct contact with research participants consenting and/or collecting data, and/or have access to private and identifiable research data.

Principal Investigator (PI): The NASA PI or PI that is responsible for coordination with the NASA IRB or the IRB of Record for all engaged research sites.

Site Investigator (local Investigator): The investigator at one of the sites where the study is occurring and is responsible to overall PI.

[2] [OHRP: Engagement of Institutions in Human Subjects Research (2008)]

Unanticipated Problem Involving Risks to Subjects or Others (UPIRSO):[3] any incident, experience, or outcome that meets all of the following:

1. unexpected (in terms of nature, severity, or frequency) given (a) the procedures described in the research protocol documents, such as the IRB-approved research protocol and informed consent document; and (b) the characteristics of the human subject population being studied,
2. is related or possibly related to participation in the research, and
3. suggests that the research places human subjects or others at a greater risk of harm (including physical, psychological, economic, or social harm) related to the research than was previously known or recognized (even if no harm has actually occurred).

References

- 14 CFR 1230
- NPR 7100.1
- 45 CFR 46.103(e), 46.114
- 21 CFR 50, 56, 312, and 812
- ICH-GCP (E6)
- AAHRPP Tip Sheet 24: Single IRB or EC Review
- NIH Policy on the Use of a Single Institutional Review Board for Multi-Site Research

Version #	Version Notes:	Originated By:	Approved By:	Date Approved:
v.4.2	Updated engaged definition, typos, typographical errors, and formatting	J. Kissling/J. Green	M. Covington	17Sep2025
v.4.1	Updated engaged definition	J. Ensley Gorshe/J. Green	M. Covington	19Mar2025
v.4	Amended responsibility for COI/Training of site personnel to relying site	J. Ensley Gorshe/J. Green	M. Covington	22May2024
v.3	Substantive revisions to process.	P. Weitzel, J. Ensley Gorshe	M. Covington	28Mar2023
v.2		J. Kisenwether	M. Covington	12Nov2020
v.1		J. Christensen	M. Covington	07Jul2020

[3] (Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP), 2007)